

How a Wayward Tortoise Named Rex United a Phoenix Suburb

From: NPR World Mined: 2026-05-18 5 min read

It was a Tuesday evening in a quiet Scottsdale, Arizona suburb when a dinosaur came strolling down the sidewalk. Rex, a massive African **sulcata** tortoise, had escaped his yard and was ambling past bewildered neighbors. "We were eating dinner and my daughter goes, 'Daddy, a tortoise!'" recalled Sara Westfall. "We go outside and we're like, 'Oh, my gosh, that's a real tortoise!' And he's huge." Rex's unexpected appearance set off a flurry of activity. Neighbors gathered, snapped photos, and began a **multi-pronged** effort to find his owner. The gentle giant at least a couple of feet long seemed unfazed by the attention. But his adventure underscores a serious issue: **sulcata** tortoises are often purchased as adorable, golf-ball-sized **hatchlings**, only to become overwhelming pets. Native to Africa, **sulcatas** are the third-largest tortoise species in the world, reaching up to 200 pounds and living as long as 150 years. They require large, grassy enclosures, warm winter shelters, and they love to dig often destroying yards and gardens. "They're so damn cute, you can't help but want one," said Dan Marchand, founder of the Phoenix **Herpetological** Sanctuary, which houses about 700 surrendered **sulcatas**. "But it doesn't take long before it's taken up your yard." Arizona is **ground zero** for the problem. Teri Boyungs, who runs a rescue in Casa Grande, takes in roughly 1,250 **sulcatas** annually and refers away another 1,000. The state's climate allows eggs to hatch easily, and each female can produce over 60 babies a year. With no government support for the **non-native** species, private rescues are overwhelmed. Rex, however, beat the odds. Thanks to a neighborhood that refused to give up, he was reunited with his owner. His story is a reminder that exotic pets come with exotic responsibilities and sometimes, it takes a village to set things right.

Word Treasure

sulcata -- A species of large tortoise native to Africa, also known as the African spurred tortoise.

herpetological -- Relating to the study of reptiles and amphibians.

hatchlings -- Newly hatched baby reptiles.

non-native -- Not originally from the area; introduced from somewhere else.

ground zero -- The central location of a problem or important activity.

multi-pronged -- Having several different parts or approaches.

Background you need

Sulcata tortoises (*Centrochelys sulcata*) are the third-largest tortoise species in the world, native to the southern Sahara desert in Africa. They can weigh up to 200 pounds and live over 100 years, making them a massive, lifelong commitment.

Arizona's warm, dry climate allows sulcatas to thrive and breed easily. A single female can lay over 60 eggs a year. As a result, unwanted tortoises often overwhelm private rescues because they are a non-native species and receive no government support for relocation or care.

The Phoenix Herpetological Sanctuary, founded by Dan Marchand, is a nonprofit organization dedicated to reptile rescue and education. Teri Boyungs runs another rescue in Casa Grande, Arizona, that handles thousands of surrendered sulcatas annually, highlighting the scale of the exotic pet problem.

Exotic pet abandonment is a widespread issue: many animals sold as cute, small pets become unmanageable. The Rex story illustrates how a community can responsibly help a lost exotic animal, but also serves as a cautionary tale about the importance of researching pet needs before buying.

Break it down

LEAD: A startling encounter--a massive tortoise on a suburban sidewalk during dinner.

+ specific: 'We were eating dinner and my daughter goes, 'Daddy, a tortoise!'... we're like, 'Oh, my gosh, that's a real tortoise!'

KEY EVENT: An escaped African sulcata tortoise named Rex wanders through a Scottsdale neighborhood.

+ WHO: Rex, the tortoise; neighborhood residents including the Westfall family.

+ WHAT: Neighbors launch a multi-pronged effort to locate his owner.

+ RESOLUTION: Rex is reunited with his owner.

BACKGROUND ON SPECIES: Sulcatas are the third-largest tortoise, native to Africa, and can live 150 years, reaching 200 pounds.

+ PROBLEM: Often sold as tiny hatchlings, they become destructive, outgrowing homes.

+ IN ARIZONA: The climate allows easy breeding; each female produces 60+ babies yearly.

RESCUE CRISIS: Phoenix Herpetological Sanctuary houses 700; Teri Boyungs takes in 1,250 per year, all private, overwhelmed.

BROADER MESSAGE: Exotic pets bring exotic responsibilities; sometimes a community makes the difference.

Why it matters

Rex's story is a reminder that the small, cute pets you might see online can grow into huge, lifelong responsibilities--and that a caring community can solve problems that might otherwise burden overwhelmed animal rescues.

Test what you remember

1. Where did Rex the tortoise appear?

- ☐ (A) In a zoo in Phoenix.
- ☐ (B) On a sidewalk in a Scottsdale, Arizona suburb.
- ☐ (C) Inside a herpetological sanctuary.
- ☐ (D) In the backyard of the Phoenix Herpetological Sanctuary.

2. Why are sulcata tortoises a problem in Arizona?

- ☐ (A) They are predators that eat local wildlife.
- ☐ (B) They are often bought as small hatchlings but grow too large and destructive for owners.
- ☐ (C) They carry diseases that infect humans.
- ☐ (D) They are an endangered species that needs government protection.

3. How many surrendered sulcatas does the Phoenix Herpetological Sanctuary house?

- ☐ (A) About 1,250 per year.
- ☐ (B) Around 700.
- ☐ (C) Over 200.
- ☐ (D) 60.

4. According to the article, how many sulcatas does Teri Boyungs's rescue take in annually?

- ☐ (A) Around 150.
- ☐ (B) About 700.
- ☐ (C) Roughly 1,250, referring away another 1,000.
- ☐ (D) Over 5,000.

5. What helped Rex find his owner?

- ☐ (A) A GPS tracker attached to his shell.
- ☐ (B) The efforts of the neighborhood.
- ☐ (C) A call from the Phoenix Herpetological Sanctuary.
- ☐ (D) Police patrols.

6. What is one challenge of owning a sulcata tortoise mentioned in the article?

- ☐ (A) They are illegal to keep in Arizona.
- ☐ (B) They can dig and destroy yards and gardens.
- ☐ (C) They live only 10 years.
- ☐ (D) They require a steady diet of other reptiles.

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: B 4: C 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Positive / Community: The neighborhood's quick, caring response shows how ordinary people can make a difference for lost animals. The happy reunion demonstrates that local goodwill can outshine official systems that are under-resourced, especially for non-native species that lack government programs.

2. Negative / Animal Welfare: The story exposes a darker side of the exotic pet trade: thousands of sulcatas are abandoned each year because buyers don't understand the long-term care. Private sanctuaries, already strained, struggle to handle the animals, leading to potential neglect or euthanasia when shelters run out of space.

3. Neutral / Systemic analysis: Arizona's climate creates a perfect storm for sulcata overpopulation, but the state does not fund rescues for non-native species. This gap forces nonprofits to fill the void, revealing a regulatory blind spot where commercial breeders profit while society bears the burden of abandoned pets.

4. **Forward-looking:** Rex's fame could inspire stronger public education campaigns about exotic pet ownership and perhaps even licensing for large, long-lived species. In the future, technology like microchipping or community alert systems could accelerate reunions, while reforms could target the root cause--irresponsible breeding and selling--to prevent similar crises.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):